

Zero-Shot, One-Shot and Few-Shot Prompting

Example Task: Classifying Customer Feedback

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Objective. To develop zero-shot, one-shot, and few-shot prompts for the same task and compare how the amount of guidance and examples affects the generated output.

1. Common Task

Task: Classify a customer review into one of three categories — Positive, Negative, or Neutral — and provide a short reason for the classification.

Input review used for comparison: “The product arrived on time and works well, but the packaging was damaged and the instructions were difficult to understand.”

2. Zero-Shot Prompt

Prompt: “Classify the following customer review as Positive, Negative, or Neutral and give a short reason. Review: The product arrived on time and works well, but the packaging was damaged and the instructions were difficult to understand.”

Example generated output: “Neutral — The review contains both positive and negative points. The product arrived on time and works well, while the damaged packaging and unclear instructions are negative aspects.”

3. One-Shot Prompt

Prompt: “Classify each customer review as Positive, Negative, or Neutral and give a short reason.

Example: Review: ‘The service was quick and the staff were helpful.’ → Positive — The customer liked the speed of service and helpful staff.

Now classify: ‘The product arrived on time and works well, but the packaging was damaged and the instructions were difficult to understand.’”

Example generated output: “Neutral — The review has positive aspects, such as timely delivery and good product performance, but also negative aspects involving the packaging and instructions.”

4. Few-Shot Prompt

Prompt: “Classify each customer review as Positive, Negative, or Neutral and give a short reason. Follow the pattern shown in these examples.

Example 1: ‘The product is excellent and exceeded my expectations.’ → Positive — The customer expresses strong satisfaction.

Example 2: ‘The item arrived broken and customer support did not respond.’ → Negative — The customer reports serious problems with the product and support.

Example 3: ‘The product is okay. It works as expected, but nothing is especially impressive.’ → Neutral — The customer gives a balanced, neither strongly positive nor strongly negative opinion.

Now classify: ‘The product arrived on time and works well, but the packaging was damaged and the instructions were difficult to understand.’”

Example generated output: “Neutral — The review includes positive points about timely delivery and product performance, but also negative points about damaged packaging and unclear instructions. Overall, the sentiment is balanced.”

5. Comparison of Generated Outputs

Prompt Type	Guidance	Output Characteristics	Overall Result
Zero-Shot	No examples are provided.	Direct and concise. The model relies on its general understanding of the task.	Correct, but interpretation may vary.
One-Shot	One example is provided.	Follows the demonstrated classification format and reasoning style.	More consistent than zero-shot.
Few-Shot	Multiple examples are provided.	More closely follows the required labels, reasoning pattern, and decision boundaries.	Most structured and consistent.

6. Conclusion

All three prompts perform the same classification task, but the amount of instruction changes how the model approaches the task. Zero-shot prompting is simple and useful when the task is already clear. One-shot prompting gives the model a single example to imitate, improving consistency. Few-shot prompting provides several examples and is generally the most useful when the expected format, categories, or decision rules need to be demonstrated clearly. In this example, all three approaches classify the review as Neutral, while the few-shot prompt provides the clearest and most structured reasoning.